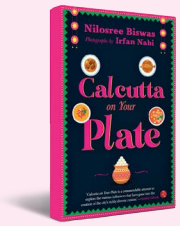
loved the inside story on their first chef and how he developed the menu before they parted ways. We expected more on the magic that has gone into the creation of an establishment that has shown extraordinary staying power in a city where restaurants come and go in the blink of an eye. The success story behind the Mag Street Café and its droolworthy offerings is also mysteriously missing from the narrative.

The tale meanders into musings about Mumbai and its buildings, repeats and backtracks at various points, and often goes off into unrelated asides, all of which could have benefited from better editing. Besides, good intentions and grand stories don't always take you to the heart of the hearth. In this case, we felt that much like the cover of *Diamonds for Breakfast*, which mentions diamonds in the title but features more pearls, the writing too, leaves one looking for a more valuable takeaway. ■

Priya Pathiyan

A TASTE OF HISTORY

NILOSREE BISWAS'S BOOK OFFERS A DEEPLY ENGAGING CULINARY RECORD OF THE CITY OF JOY



CALCUTTA ON YOUR PLATE
by Nilosree Biswas; photographs by Irfan Nabi
RUPA PUBLICATIONS
₹395; 198 pages

Earlier this year, Kolkata became the only Indian city to feature on the 2023 list of the world's top 11 food destinations, as adjudged annually by the award-winning digital platform *Eater*. Amidst the celebratory articles that ensued, detailing the diversity of Kolkata's food and why it made for a clear winner, a few couldn't help but wonder just how it could've beaten other cities to the punch. *Eater* offered some explanation on that front: "In picking 2023's dining destinations, we thought not just about hit lists and must-try dishes...but also the aspects of meals that make them feel immersive: the people, environment, culture and history behind foods that force us to pause and tempt us from preplanned paths."

It is these very aspects that have shaped Kolkata's culinary landscape—precisely 250 years of political, social and cultural history—that find in-depth exploration in author and filmmaker Nilosree Biswas's new book, *Calcutta on Your Plate* (2022). Throughout its comparatively short existence, Kolkata's foodscape as we know it today has undergone a sea change, with traditional habits that existed from mediaeval times being influenced by two distinct cooking styles—the English and the Mughlai-Awadhi—with considerable contributions from the Portuguese.

> Kolkata's food today is a result of **mediaeval traditions mingling with** Mughlai-Awadhi, English and Portuguese cuisines

To understand Kolkata's food is to understand its history, its people and their aspirations, which pushed the boundaries of Bengal's traditional gastronomy through acceptance, innovation and celebration.

The book thus begins from the beginning, when the city of Calcutta was established by an East India Company agent, Job Charnock. The first imperial capital of India was shaped by generations of British officers over 200 years. Being a nerve centre of commerce in the region also meant that Calcutta's foodscape would come to be influenced by the Dutch, Armenians, Afghans, the Chinese and, most crucially, the Portuguese, who introduced many ingredients to Bengali cuisine, including cheese, pineapple and the ubiquitous potato.

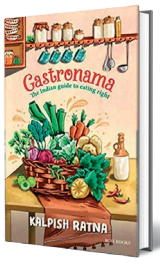
Over four non-linear chapters, Biswas also details the influence that the last king of Awadh, Nawab Wajid Ali Shah, and his workers brought to Calcutta's food scene when they settled here in exile, creating a mini-Lucknow in Metiabruz. But most instrumental in shaping the cuisine was perhaps the landed gentry of Bengali *babus* and their wives, whose aspirations for a life mirroring their colonisers meant accepting, assimilating and celebrating all the new ingredients, dishes and ways of cooking. Besides being an engaging dive into the city's food history, *Calcutta on Your Plate* also paints a delicious panorama with liberal descriptions of the many dishes that have come to define the city's food. ■

Satarupa Paul



EATING THE PRESENT, TASTING THE FUTURE: Exploring India Through Her Changing Food
by Charmaine O'Brien
PENGUIN INDIA **₹399; 392** pages

Culinary historian Charmaine O'Brien joyfully describes eating in people's homes, canteens, and upscale restaurants around India over the years, and includes inputs from chefs, writers, restaurateurs and historians who've helped enhance the regional food game. Discussing nostalgia, urbanisation and convenience, O'Brien also touches on how technology has aided food writing. An enjoyable read that offers a culinary panorama of contemporary India.



GASTRONAMA: The Indian Guide to Eating Right
by Kalpish Ratna
ROLI BOOKS **₹495; 360** pages

Most animals are driven to eat by hunger, but for humans today, eating is driven by taste. Kalpish Ratna (the joint pen name of surgeons Ishrat Syed and Kalpana Swaminathan) get this right in their new book. They break down the 'what' and 'why' of the food we consume and 'how' it affects the body, the nature of lifestyle diseases, while also tackling paradoxes and perceptions and discussing ways to get the best out of ingredients. The accessibly written book tells us what eating correctly means. The question is, will one follow it?